守株待兔和别的故事

周老师的四个故事

Waiting by the Tree, and Other Fables

Four stories from Mr Zhou

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 3 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 周老师是四年级二班的语文老师。他有一个习惯：每天上课以前，先给学生讲一个小故事。这个星期，二班的篮球队正在准备学校的比赛。周老师发现，他的故事突然变得特别有用了。

第一个故事：守株待兔†

2 星期一早上，王小东‡一进教室就大声说："我们赢了！我们赢了！"原来，上个星期五，二班要和三班打一场篮球比赛。可是那天下大雨，三班的队员一个都没来，所以二班没打就赢了。小东§是篮球队的队长，他非常高兴。

3 "星期五还有一场比赛，我们要不要练习？"一个同学问。小东笑着说："不用！也许那天又下雨，对手又不来呢。"林月¶平时最认真，这次也没说要练习。

† 守株待兔 *shǒuzhū dàitù* to wait by a tree for rabbits

‡ 王小东 *Wáng Xiǎodōng* Wang Xiaodong

§ 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong

¶ 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue

Mr Zhou taught Chinese to Class Two in the fourth grade. He had a habit: every day, before the lesson began, he told his students a little story. That week, Class Two's basketball team was getting ready for the school tournament, and Mr Zhou found that his stories had suddenly become very useful. 1

The First Story: Waiting by the Tree for Rabbits

On Monday morning, the moment Wang Xiaodong walked into the classroom, he shouted, "We won! We won!" Last Friday, it turned out, Class Two had been due to play a basketball game against Class Three. But it poured with rain that day and not one player from Class Three turned up, so Class Two won without playing at all. Xiaodong was the team captain, and he was overjoyed. 2

"There's another game on Friday. Should we practise?" a classmate asked. Xiaodong laughed. "No need! Maybe it'll rain again that day and the other team won't turn up again." Lin Yue, usually the most serious of them all, didn't say they should practise either. 3

周老师听了，没有说什么，只是在黑板上写了四个字：守株待兔[†]。

“今天，我给大家讲一个两千多年前的故事。”周老师说。古时候，宋国[‡]有一个农民，每天都在地里干活。有一天，一只兔子[§]从草里跑出来，跑得太快了，一下撞[¶]在地边的树上，死了。农民走过去一看，高兴地说：“今天真是太好了！我连手都没动，就得到了一只兔子！”

第二天，农民没有去干活，就坐在地边的树下等着。他想：“只要我在这里等，就会有兔子来撞树。”他等了一天，没有兔子。他等了十天，还是没有兔子。一天一天过去了，地里的草越来越高，可是没有一只兔子再来过。最后，他的地里什么也没长出来，这个农民也成了大家的笑话。

† 守株待兔 *shǒuzhū dàitù* to wait by a tree for rabbits

‡ 宋国 *Sòngguó* the State of Song

§ 兔子 *tùzi* rabbit

¶ 撞 *zhuàng* to crash into

Mr Zhou heard this and said nothing. He just wrote four characters on the blackboard: 守株待兔, "waiting by a tree for rabbits". 3

"Today I'll tell you a story from more than two thousand years ago," said Mr Zhou. Long ago, in the State of Song, there lived a farmer who worked in his field every day. One day a rabbit dashed out of the grass so fast that it ran straight into a tree at the edge of the field and died. The farmer went over to look and said happily, "What a day! I didn't even lift a finger, and I've got myself a rabbit!" 4

The next day the farmer didn't work. He just sat under the tree at the edge of the field and waited. He thought, "As long as I wait here, another rabbit will come and run into the tree." He waited one day: no rabbit. He waited ten days: still no rabbit. Day after day went by, and the weeds in his field grew taller and taller, but no rabbit ever came again. In the end nothing at all grew in his field, and the farmer became a laughing stock. 5

6 周老师讲完，问：“这个农民为什么什么都没有得到？”同学们都看着小东[†]，小东的脸一下就红了。“我知道了。”他说，“我们不能等着对手不来，我们应该自己去练习。”“对。”周老师笑着说，“难道每次比赛都会下大雨吗？”那天下午，二班的篮球队就开始练习了。

第二个故事：画蛇添足[‡]

7 星期一练习以后，同学们决定为篮球队画一张大画，挂在教室门口。他们画了绿色的球场、红色的篮球，还有五个穿蓝衣服的队员。林月[§]说：“好了，很好看！”可是小东说：“还不够，还不够！”他拿起笔，在天上加了一个太阳，又加了几只鸟，后来又加了一条大龙。别的同学也开始往上加：花、树、小狗、飞机……最后，画上什么都有，连队员的脸都看不清楚了。

† 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong

‡ 画蛇添足 *huàshé tiānzú* to draw legs on a snake

§ 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue

When he had finished, Mr Zhou asked, "Why did this farmer end up with nothing?" Everyone looked at Xiaodong, and Xiaodong's face turned red. "I get it," he said. "We can't just wait for the other team not to come. We should go and practise." "Right," said Mr Zhou with a smile. "Surely it isn't going to pour with rain every time you have a game?" That very afternoon, Class Two's basketball team started practising. 6

The Second Story: Drawing Legs on a Snake

After practice on Monday, the class decided to paint a big picture for the basketball team and hang it outside the classroom door. They painted a green court, a red basketball and five players in blue. Lin Yue said, "That's it, it looks great!" But Xiaodong said, "It's not enough yet, not nearly enough!" He picked up a brush and added a sun in the sky, then a few birds, and then a great big dragon. The others began adding things too: flowers, trees, puppies, planes... In the end the picture had everything in it, and you couldn't even make out the players' faces. 7

8 星期二早上，周老师站在门口看了半天，问：“这是篮球比赛吗？我还以为是动物园呢。”他走进教室，又在黑板上写了四个字：画蛇添足[†]。

9 古时候，楚国[‡]有一家人请几个帮忙的人喝酒。可是酒只有一点儿，一个人喝正好，几个人喝就不够了。有人说：“我们在地上画蛇[§]吧。谁先画完，酒就给谁喝。”有一个人画得最快，很快就画好了。他拿起酒，看见别人还在画，就笑着说：“你们太慢了！我还有时间给蛇画几只脚呢！”

10 他左手拿着酒，右手给蛇画脚。脚还没画完，旁边的人已经画好了。那个人把酒拿了过去，说：“蛇本来就没有脚，你画的根本不是蛇！”说完，他就把酒喝了。“画蛇添足，”周老师说，“就是做了不需要做的事，结果把本来很好的东西变得不好了。”

† 画蛇添足 *huàshé tiānzú* to draw legs on a snake

‡ 楚国 *Chǔguó* the State of Chu

§ 蛇 *shé* snake

On Tuesday morning Mr Zhou stood at the door looking at it for a long time, 8
then asked, "Is this a basketball game? I thought it was a zoo." He walked into the classroom and wrote four more characters on the blackboard: 画蛇添足, "drawing legs on a snake".

Long ago, in the State of Chu, a family invited a few people who had been 9
helping them to have some wine. But there was only a little wine: just right for one person, but not enough for several. Someone said, "Let's each draw a snake on the ground. Whoever finishes first gets the wine." One man drew fastest and was soon done. He picked up the wine, saw that the others were still drawing, and laughed. "You're so slow! I've still got time to give my snake some feet!"

With the wine in his left hand, he drew feet on the snake with his right. 10
Before he had finished the feet, the man next to him had finished his snake. That man took the wine from him and said, "Snakes don't have feet! What you've drawn isn't a snake at all!" And with that, he drank the wine. "Drawing legs on a snake," said Mr Zhou, "means doing something that doesn't need doing, and spoiling something that was fine to begin with."

11 小东[†]看着门口的画，不好意思地笑了。那天中午，大家又画了一张新的。这一次，画完以后，连小东都说："好了，好了，一笔也不要再加了！"

第三个故事：亡羊补牢[‡]

12 星期二下午，篮球队又去球场练习。小东拿着装球的大包走在最前面。到了球场，他打开包一看，少了一个球！原来包的下面破了一个口，球是从那里掉出去的。

13 林月[§]说："我们得把包补一补，要不然球还会掉出去的。"小东说："球已经没有了，现在补还有什么用？而且包里还有三个球呢。"那天晚上，谁也没有补那个包。

† 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong

‡ 亡羊补牢 *wángyáng bǔláo* to mend the pen after losing sheep

§ 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue

Xiaodong looked at the picture by the door and gave an embarrassed smile. 11
At lunchtime that day, they painted a new one. This time, when it was finished, even Xiaodong said, "That's it, that's it, not one more brushstroke!"

The Third Story: Mending the Pen After the Sheep Is Lost

On Tuesday afternoon the basketball team went to the court to practise 12
again. Xiaodong walked in front, carrying the big bag the balls were kept in. When they got to the court, he opened the bag and found a ball was missing! There was a hole in the bottom of the bag, and the ball had fallen out through it.

Lin Yue said, "We'd better mend the bag, or more balls will fall out." Xi- 13
aodong said, "The ball's gone already. What's the use of mending it now? Besides, there are still three balls in the bag." That evening, nobody mended the bag.

14 星期三早上，周老师在黑板上写下：亡羊补牢[†]。从前，有一个人养了很多羊。一天早上，他发现少了一只羊。原来，羊圈[‡]的墙上破了一个口，夜里狼[§]从那里进来，把羊带走了。他的朋友说："快把羊圈修一修吧，要不然狼还会来的！"他说："羊已经没有了，还修羊圈干什么？"

15 第二天早上，他又少了一只羊。狼果然又从那个口进来了。这一次，他马上把羊圈修好了。从那以后，狼就进不来了，他的羊也没有再少过。周老师说："羊没有了再修羊圈，当然晚了一点儿。可是只要马上去修，就不会太晚。"

16 小东[¶]站了起来，说："周老师，我明白了。难道我们要等第二个球也掉了，才去补包吗？"那天中午，小东和林月[*]一起把包补好了。下午练习的时候，大家看了好几次包，球果然一个也没少。

† 亡羊补牢 *wángyáng bǔláo* to mend the pen after losing sheep
‡ 羊圈 *yángjuàn* sheep pen
§ 狼 *láng* wolf
¶ 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong
* 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue

On Wednesday morning Mr Zhou wrote on the blackboard: 亡羊补牢, 14
"mending the pen after the sheep is lost". Once upon a time, there was a man who kept a lot of sheep. One morning he found that a sheep was missing. There was a hole in the wall of the sheep pen, and in the night a wolf had got in through it and carried the sheep off. His friend said, "Hurry up and mend your pen, or the wolf will come back!" He said, "The sheep's already gone. What's the point of mending the pen?"

The next morning, another sheep was gone. Sure enough, the wolf had 15
come in through the same hole again. This time he mended the pen at once. After that the wolf could not get in, and he never lost another sheep. Mr Zhou said, "Mending the pen after a sheep is lost is a bit late, of course. But as long as you mend it straight away, it's not too late."

Xiaodong stood up and said, "Mr Zhou, I understand. We're not going 16
to wait until a second ball falls out before we mend the bag, are we?" At lunchtime, Xiaodong and Lin Yue mended the bag together. At practice that afternoon they checked the bag again and again, and sure enough, not a single ball was missing.

第四个故事：井底之蛙[1]

17 星期三下午，二班和一班、三班各打了一场比赛，两场都赢了。小东[2]越来越高兴，大声说："我们现在是全校最好的球队！我看，市里的大学生也不是我们的对手！"别的同学都跟着他喊，只有林月[3]没有说话。

18 星期四早上，周老师刚走进教室，林月就举起了手："周老师，今天的故事，能让我来讲吗？"周老师笑着点了点头。林月走到黑板前面，写了四个字：井底之蛙。

19 从前，有一只青蛙[4]住在一口老井[5]里。它每天在井里跳来跳去，觉得自己是世界上最快乐的动物。有一天，一只大海龟[6]从东海[7]来，走到了井边。

1 井底之蛙 *jǐngdǐ zhīwā* a frog at the bottom of a well
2 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong
3 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue
4 青蛙 *qīngwā* frog
5 井 *jǐng* well
6 海龟 *hǎiguī* sea turtle
7 东海 *Dōng Hǎi* the East China Sea

The Fourth Story: The Frog at the Bottom of the Well

On Wednesday afternoon, Class Two played a game each against Class One and Class Three, and won both. Xiaodong grew happier and happier, and announced loudly, "We're the best team in the school now! If you ask me, even the university students in town couldn't beat us!" The others all cheered along with him. Only Lin Yue said nothing. 17

On Thursday morning, Mr Zhou had only just walked into the classroom when Lin Yue put up her hand. "Mr Zhou, could I tell today's story?" Mr Zhou smiled and nodded. Lin Yue went up to the blackboard and wrote four characters: 井底之蛙, "the frog at the bottom of the well". 18

Once upon a time, a frog lived in an old well. Every day it hopped about in the well and thought it was the happiest animal in the world. One day a big sea turtle from the Eastern Sea came walking up to the well. 19

19 青蛙[†]说：“你看，我的家多大啊！我想跳就跳，想游就游。你难道不想下来看看吗？”海龟[‡]很想下去，可是它太大了，连一只脚都放不进去。

20 海龟对青蛙说：“你见过大海吗？大海大得没有边。下十年大雨，大海的水也不会多；十年不下雨，大海的水也不会少。住在大海里，那才是真的快乐呢。”青蛙听了，半天说不出话来。

21 林月[§]讲完，说：“井底之蛙[¶]，就是只看见身边的一点儿东西，就以为看见了整个世界的人。”小东[*]问：“难道我们不是最好的吗？”林月笑着说：“也许是吧。可是我们连学校的大门都还没出过呢！”大家都笑了，小东也笑了。

22 星期五，二班赢了三班。星期六，他们又去和别的学校打了一场，结果输了十几分。

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† 青蛙 *qīngwā* frog
‡ 海龟 *hǎiguī* sea turtle
§ 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue
¶ 井底之蛙 *jǐngdǐ zhīwā* a frog at the bottom of a well
* 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong

The frog said, "Look how big my home is! I hop when I want to hop and swim when I want to swim. Don't you want to come down and have a look?" The turtle would have liked to go down, but it was far too big. It couldn't even get one foot in. 19

The turtle said to the frog, "Have you ever seen the sea? The sea is so big it has no edge. Ten years of heavy rain won't make it any fuller, and ten years without rain won't make it any emptier. Living in the sea: now that's real happiness." When the frog heard this, it couldn't say a word for a long time. 20

When she had finished, Lin Yue said, "A frog at the bottom of a well is someone who sees only the little bit of the world around them and thinks they have seen all of it." Xiaodong asked, "What, you mean we're not the best?" Lin Yue smiled. "Maybe we are. But we haven't even been outside the school gate yet!" Everyone laughed, Xiaodong included. 21

On Friday, Class Two beat Class Three. On Saturday they went to play a team from another school, and lost by more than ten points. 22

22 小东†说：“林月‡说得对，我们果然不是最好的。不过，只要每天练习，我们就会越来越好。”下个星期一，周老师一走进教室，小东就站了起来：“周老师，今天的故事，让我来讲吧！”

† 小东 *Xiǎodōng* Xiaodong

‡ 林月 *Lín Yuè* Lin Yue

Xiaodong said, "Lin Yue was right. We're not the best after all. But as long as 22
we practise every day, we'll keep getting better." The next Monday, as soon as Mr Zhou walked into the classroom, Xiaodong stood up. "Mr Zhou, let me tell today's story!"